

13, Why the Political Reforms During Emperor Wu's Reign Ultimately Led China Down a Catastrophic Path

However, as I have previously articulated as my most paramount conclusion: although China progressed rapidly during early *feudalization* (封建化), this can hardly be deemed a good thing. The bureaucratic system forged during the Western Han Dynasty ultimately mutated into a force that obstructed *feudalization*, triggering its disruption and leading to a catastrophic *bureaucratic restoration* (官僚复辟).

Previously, I merely stated in broad strokes that the bureaucratic system formed in the Han Dynasty was "too strong," without specifying *how* it was strong. Furthermore, merely using the word "strong" might invite misinterpretation.

Therefore, let us return to the historical turning point and meticulously investigate the "**crime scene**" (案发现场). Although Emperor Wu's 54-year reign holistically constitutes the turning point in Chinese history, for the sake of granular scrutiny, we might as well narrow the timeframe specifically to the two years between 121 BC and 120 BC. Let us observe the crossroads at which the Han Dynasty stood at this exact juncture.

First, Huo Qubing's (霍去病) two offensives in 121 BC enabled the Han Dynasty to conquer the entire Hexi Corridor (河西走廊). The encirclement of the Han Dynasty by peripheral minority regimes like the Xiongnu completely disintegrated. Following the conquest of the Hexi Corridor, the Han Empire's control over the North reached the absolute maximum extent achievable by subsequent dynasties. Regions suitable for agriculture were entirely occupied, and certain mixed agro-pastoral zones and horse-breeding pastures were secured.

Second, following the failed rebellion of Liu An, the Prince of Huainan (淮南王刘安), in 122 BC, Emperor Wu successively promulgated the *Law of Left Officialdom* (左官律) and the *Law of Appended Benefits* (附益法). This unequivocally marked the completion of the usurpation of the rights of the vassal kingdoms. Thereafter, it was fundamentally impossible for the Han imperial court to extract any further lucrative resources from the vassal kingdoms.

Third, Emperor Wu established the Imperial Academy (太学) in 124 BC. This, combined with previous measures such as establishing the Erudites of the Five Classics (五经博士) and perfecting the *Chaju* system (察举制 / recommendation system), basically completed the construction of the ideological framework (*primarily Confucian*) of the Chinese bureaucratic system. This framework, holistically speaking, persisted uninterrupted until the late Qing Dynasty.

Fourth, following the Hexi campaigns, the surplus wealth accumulated during the reigns of Emperors Wen and Jing had been virtually exhausted by the Xiongnu wars. Continuing the war inevitably meant pioneering new sources of revenue. Achieving this in the short term could absolutely not rely on the organic growth of productive forces; it had to rely on a **novel, extractive institutional mechanism** (新的榨取制度).

By this point, the successful counteroffensive against the Xiongnu meant the empire no longer faced an existential crisis. A monumental strategic dilemma thus arose (*judged from our modern perspective with comprehensive information*): Should the empire transition into a state of defensive counterattack at geographical positions relatively close to the hinterland—zones situated at the ecological boundaries of precipitation and production modes—using its residual strength to sweep

peripheral regimes? Or should it seize the moment when the Xiongnu were severely crippled to proactively expand the war, dispatching even larger armies deep into the Mongolian heartland to relentlessly pursue a fleeing enemy?

However, at the time, people seemingly did not lean toward making peace. This was not merely because the information available back then was incomplete, but more critically because a century of crushing military oppression by the Xiongnu made it exceedingly difficult for people to believe that the Xiongnu armies would not stage a devastating comeback. After all, when Modu Chanyu (冒顿单于) commenced his conquests, the Hetao region and the Hexi Corridor were not ruled by the Xiongnu either.

At that specific juncture, the only official who resolutely advocated for "quitting while ahead" and restoring peace with the Xiongnu was the Chief Commandant of Nobility, Ji An (主爵都尉汲黯). Yet, this man did not necessarily foresee any systemic crisis; highly likely, it was simply because he consistently revered the Daoist principle of "minimizing state interference" (国家少事), and felt that after winning a few battles, negotiating peace was merely more appropriate. In summary, the empire's ultimate decision was to relentlessly expand the war, its final objective potentially already having evolved into the absolute annihilation of the Xiongnu.

Consequently, following the death of Gongsun Hong (公孙弘) in 121 BC—the very last Chancellor (丞相) within the core decision-making circle during Emperor Wu's reign—until Tian Qianqiu (田千秋) was summoned to assist the crown prince Liu Fuling, the historical records show **absolutely no Chancellor of the Han Empire playing any substantive role in the decision-making echelon.**

This marked the absolute segregation of the "Inner Court" (内朝) and the "Outer Court" (外朝).

Now, the classical imperial court—teeming with eccentric talents and exotic advisors from all walks of life—contracted into the Inner Court, headed by the Commander-in-Chief and General-in-Chief, Wei Qing (大司马大将军卫青). Members of the Inner Court, acting as the emperor's intimate confidants, directly participated in the deliberation and decision-making process of grand national strategies. Meanwhile, the Outer Court bureaucracy, headed by the Chancellor, did not play any influential role in political decision-making, existing merely as the executive apparatus of the imperial government.

This novel institutional apparatus rapidly demonstrated an aggressively formidable working efficiency. Over the ensuing decade, Emperor Wu executed two predatory currency reforms, ultimately standardizing the currency and monopolizing the right of coinage. He launched the *Suanmin* and *Gaomin* campaigns (算缗和告缗运动)—a terrifying movement of "national informant snitching" (全民检举揭发) that **utterly bankrupted all merchants from the middle class upwards.** He initiated the policies of state monopoly over salt and iron (盐铁官营) and the *Pingzhun* and *Junshu* systems (平准均输 / equitable delivery and price stabilization), drastically fortifying the state's capacity to control the economy.

It was precisely through these draconian measures to alleviate economic pressure that Emperor Wu was able to sustain his wars of conquest and exploratory expeditions for another 30 years, marking the very first time China appeared on the world stage as a formidable superpower.

Thus, we can explicitly unravel how Emperor Wu's political maneuvers meticulously sculpted the characteristics that ultimately enabled the restoration of the Chinese bureaucratic system.

First, unlike any other nation, the Chinese Empire during Emperor Wu's reign developed a bureaucratic system that was unprecedentedly unique. It possessed a heavily defined guiding ideology (Confucianism); it featured a massive array of both public and private academies, alongside state-sanctioned scholars and prestigious Great Confucians (大儒) responsible for cultivating the bureaucracy's reserve force; and it utilized a relatively explicit official-selection system that the bureaucracy possessed substantial authority to execute autonomously (*though the highest-ranking officials naturally still required imperial approval*). **Crucially, this system encompassed the entire nation, not merely fragmented regions.**

For one or two of these characteristics to appear in isolation is not unusual, but for all of them to converge simultaneously within the bureaucratic system of a **classical period** (古典时期) is genuinely astonishing.

The general characteristics of a **classical empire's** bureaucratic system lie precisely in its *arbitrariness* and *balance*. That is to say, it does not exclusively select one specific type of person; the ultimate result is a system brimming with a staggering diversity of personnel. It is not a religious order (教团); it is a state apparatus wielding immense power. Given the prosperity and openness of myriad ideologies during the **classical period**, the intellectual inclinations of the members within a classical bureaucratic system should naturally be highly diverse.

Furthermore, we must point out that under normal circumstances, maintaining this diversity within the bureaucratic system is actually phenomenally beneficial for the absolute despotic power of the monarch. For instance, the monarchs of Sasanian Persia (萨珊波斯) were extraordinarily fond of—and highly adept at—expanding their own power by pitting Zoroastrianism, Manichaeism, various Christian sects, and the Mazdakite movement against one another in fierce competition. Similarly, the monarchs of the Maurya and Gupta Dynasties simultaneously patronized Brahmanism, Buddhism, Jainism, and the Ajivika (阿吉维卡派) sect.

The subsequent trajectory of Chinese history also proves that establishing Confucianism as the exclusive state ideology (独尊儒术) fundamentally *did not* increase the monarch's actual power in practice. Following Emperor Wu, the power of Han monarchs relative to the bureaucratic system did not exhibit an upward trajectory; on the contrary, it trended toward weakness. This is because a bureaucratic system operating under a unified guiding ideology was never originally designed to enhance the power of a classical monarch. **Rather, confronted with the brutal realities of relentlessly expanding warfare, it was designed to maximize administrative execution efficiency and to conserve the phenomenal energy the emperor personally expended on maintaining daily administration.**

The "Outer Court" (外朝) bureaucratic system during Emperor Wu's reign functioned effectively as the **exoskeleton** (外骨骼) of the entire imperial government. For this appended machine to operate normally and autonomously—without constantly plunging into a state requiring manual repair—the emperor had to input the "software program" of Confucian ideology into it.

However, a bureaucratic system possessing a guiding ideology, academic institutions, and explicit promotional pathways inevitably spawns a novel mutation: **the awakening of a "self-consciousness" (自我意识) from within the bureaucracy.** Multitudes of bureaucrats recognized that they shared monumental common interests, and from the perspective of official selection and performance evaluations, this was undeniably true.

Concurrently, a massive demographic of beneficiaries wholly parasitic upon this bureaucratic system emerged. In reality, this occurred almost immediately following Emperor Wu's death—namely, the emergence of the Han Dynasty's "families of classical scholarship" (经学世家). The reason certain Great Confucians were deeply revered was not due to the actual practical utility of their scholarship, but simply because studying under their tutelage made it phenomenally easier to secure an official post. This was driven not only by academic pedigree but, more importantly, by social networking (社交关系).

Ultimately, these dependents of the bureaucratic system coalesced into a highly specialized stratum within our nation: **the Scholar-official stratum** (士大夫阶层).

Under these circumstances, **safeguarding the very existence of the bureaucratic system itself**—rather than merely utilizing the bureaucracy to expropriate wealth and land—mutated into the fundamental core interest of a significant segment of the population. This differs radically from Rome. Although Rome possessed a highly developed bureaucratic system, when individuals sought promotion within that system, they were overwhelmingly thinking about accumulating more wealth and purchasing more estates for their own families. They were merely riding the tide within the system and possessed zero burning desire to actively safeguard the existing institutional structure.

Since China's bureaucratic system boasted a massive cohort of vested interests defending it, possessed relatively broad mutual identification among its members, and wielded substantial autonomous operational capacity, whenever it faced monumental historical shifts, it possessed both the inexhaustible motivation and the lethal capability to react swiftly and effectively—ensuring its own adaptation, survival, and ultimate dominance.

Second, the greatest characteristic of the bureaucratic system forged during Emperor Wu's reign was not its "capacity to govern," but its "**capacity to plunder**" (能抢). This is a critical reality that many people—especially foreigners—easily overlook.

Contemporary perceptions of the Chinese bureaucratic system frequently operate under the illusion that it is highly complex, mature, and omnipotent. But this is, in fact, a pure fantasy. My evaluation is simple: live in China for a few years, and you will understand perfectly.

One merely needs to contrast Rome with the Han Dynasty to readily realize this point. In terms of the professionalization and microscopic refinement of its bureaucratic apparatus, the Han Dynasty was fundamentally incapable of comparing with Rome. This is entirely natural; after all, the civilizational development of the Eastern Mediterranean spanned a vastly longer timeframe than China's, and interactions between various regions there were phenomenally frequent. For instance, regarding jurisprudence, auditing, and public works, Rome conspicuously possessed an overwhelming advantage over the Han Empire. If we assess the deep intervention into socio-economics, the Romans were highly likely far more comprehensive and thorough.

Of course, one should not forget that it is impossible for us to accurately compare the relative strength of **infrastructural power** (基础性权力) between two massive **classical empires**. This is because even within a single empire, the court's power over different regions varies significantly. For instance, the granting of Roman citizenship remained regional for a long period; one could not possibly expect the Roman Empire's **infrastructural power** in the Italian Peninsula to be equal to that in its various provinces. The Han Dynasty is a similar case, as the political tasks assigned to different commanderies (Jun / 郡) could differ vastly.

Overall, however, the **infrastructural power** commanded by both the Han and Roman Empires was quite astonishing. Emperor Wu of Han's ability to conduct long-term, effective military mobilizations and expansionist wars during his reign over China was entirely inseparable from the formidable **infrastructural power** controlled by the imperial government. If relying solely on **despotic power** (专制性权力) were enough to defeat a formidable enemy like the Xiongnu, then Emperor Chongzhen (of the late Ming Dynasty) would never have ended up hanging himself on Jingshan (景山).

The point I wish to convey here is that the institutional reforms (*Genghua* / 更化) during Emperor Wu's lengthy reign paved the way for the formation of a highly destructive bureaucratic system capable of providing immense **despotic power**. Although, as we will soon see, Liu Che (Emperor Wu) himself was consistently, cautiously, and wisely concealing this **despotic power**.

However, during that highly specific historical epoch of Emperor Wu's reign, **the primary mission of the bureaucratic system was absolutely not "capacity to govern"; it was "capacity to plunder"**. This was because the supreme objective of the empire was to win the war.

Recall when we previously mentioned how the Qing Dynasty, after conquering China, absorbed the harsh lessons of the Ming emperors. The Qing deliberately utilized the Eight Banners system (八旗)—an apparatus they already possessed upon "Entering the Pass" (入关)—to explicitly separate ordinary administrative officials from specialized officials tasked with expanding and safeguarding the monarch's personal interests. This historical fact is monumental. **It proves that certain bureaucratic systems are inherently designed with a primary objective that has absolutely nothing to do with "enhancing governance"**—despite the general assumption that officials exist to "manage."

When Emperor Wu designed this institutional apparatus, his primary consideration was undeniably not how to ensure the impartial adjudication of judicial cases. Instead, his sole focus was on **how to systematically and continuously expropriate civilian wealth on a massive scale to fuel his wars**.

A bureaucratic system forged under such motives will inevitably mutate into an **extractive bureaucratic system** (榨取型官僚制度) rather than a **governance-oriented bureaucratic system** (治理型官僚制度). When we associate this with the classification of officials during the Qing Dynasty, we realize that, in essence, specialized bureaucrats tasked with expanding the monarch's wealth and specialized bureaucrats tasked with safeguarding the monarch's political security belong to the exact same category: they are purely "**servant-type**" (仆人型).

Therefore, when the **classical period** passed and China genuinely no longer needed to confront foreign wars on the astronomical scale and intensity of the Han-Xiongnu Wars, this **extractive bureaucratic system** effortlessly mutated into an **oppressive bureaucratic system** (压迫型官僚制度)—transforming into a monolithic apparatus whose primary objective was maintaining stability and suffocating all mutations.

In fact, it is exceptionally easy for people to comprehend this logic: **the most potent instrument of oppression is extraction itself**. As long as the common people are kept sufficiently destitute and ignorant, they are fundamentally incapable of posing any threat. This is exactly what the *Book of Lord Shang* (商君书) pointed out 2,300 years ago.

Precisely because the entire bureaucratic system is predatory rather than governance-oriented, the pathological hyper-expansion of this bureaucracy can directly annihilate social production—**this is the true root cause of the so-called "Dynastic Cycle" (王朝周期律)**. If one is familiar with the subsequent history of the Chinese Empire, particularly the history of the *restoration-bureaucratic period* (复辟官僚时期) since the Sui and Tang dynasties, this becomes glaringly obvious.

Regarding the state apparatus's capacity to manage the grassroots of society, the Chinese Empire was not necessarily superior to any other region; it might not have even surpassed medieval feudal Europe. When confronted with judicial cases, was there a procedure that could genuinely satisfy the entire society? When drafting financial budgets and conducting audits, was there an explicit process to establish accountability? Were there highly efficient market management departments to regulate the economy and stimulate market vitality?

The truth is, the Chinese Empire neither could accomplish these things nor did it care about them in the slightest. It was never designed to solve social problems; its sole requirement was the capacity to endlessly expropriate the blood and sweat of the people (掠夺民脂民膏) while simultaneously preventing rebellions. That was entirely sufficient.

Numerous folk sayings in China reflect this profound realization, such as *"Beat both sides fifty times with the heavy bamboo"* (各打五十大板 / punishing the innocent and guilty indiscriminately) and *"The yamen gates open toward the south; if you have a righteous cause but no money, do not enter."* (衙门口朝南开, 有理没钱莫进来). Even today, a highly popular internet idiom in the Chinese cybersphere perfectly encapsulates this: **"If you can't solve the problem, solve the person who raised the problem."** (解决不了问题就解决提出问题的人).

Regarding the true essence of our nation's bureaucratic system: it absolutely does not seek the long-term development of the nation or strive to do "good deeds." Instead, it seeks to plunder as much as humanly possible, committing "evil deeds." **Its formidable power lies in destruction, not construction; its mechanism is to terrorize the people, not to convince them.**

We must concede that this specific choice made by the Chinese Empire perfectly aligns with the fundamental logic of politics. For rulers to force the ruled into submission, there are essentially only three methods: bestowing favors to co-opt them, applying punishments to terrorize them, and implementing moral instruction to convince them. Rewarding requires construction, convincing requires facts, **but punishing carries the absolute lowest cost.** Rather than expending monumental effort to make the people genuinely submit with joy and admiration (心悦诚服), it is infinitely easier to manufacture endless terror and drive them all utterly insane with fear.

I firmly believe that anyone who has lived in China for a period of time—and still retains the capacity for independent thought—would find it impossible to believe that contemporary China genuinely surpasses Western developed nations in the realm of public services. (*One merely needs to recall the attitude they are subjected to when handling affairs at public institutions to immediately understand this*).

The genesis of such catastrophic consequences stems precisely from the fact that this institutional apparatus was *never* a regular governance system established by Emperor Wu; it was a **"wartime system"** (战时体制) forcefully erected because there were simply no other options available in that era. As mentioned previously, the emperor himself was equally hesitant regarding the extent to which this system should be executed and when it should be curtailed. Ultimately, however, his

megalomaniacal ambition to utterly obliterate the Xiongnu triumphed over all other rational judgments.

After the **classical period** concluded (*with the onset of feudalization*), massive-scale conflicts like the Han-Xiongnu Wars could fundamentally no longer be waged. All conquerable territories had been thoroughly annexed into the empire's pocket. There was no longer any necessity to dispatch countless explorers into the unknown distance to seek alliances, nor were there myriad grand engineering projects requiring monumental investment. In short, the colossal wealth extracted by the state had nowhere left to go.

Yet, the bureaucratic system persisted in "*plucking every last ounce of wealth*" (取之尽锱铢) from the people.

Therefore, as is glaringly evident today, the inevitable consequence was this: from the emperor at the absolute zenith down to the lowliest clerks at the grassroots, everyone acquired astronomical privileges strictly dictated by their hierarchical gradations within the bureaucratic system—and they uniformly coalesced to safeguard this exact apparatus.

As an ordinary individual, although I find it phenomenally difficult to fathom the sheer magnitude of the privileges wielded by the monarch and high-ranking bureaucrats, the undeniable historical reality is that these privileges have proven to be an absolutely irresistible temptation across the entirety of Chinese history. Anyone—regardless of their origins, their identity, or the specific modalities of their rise to power—the moment they secure such privileges, will exhaust every conceivable method to perpetuate the bureaucratic system and fiercely clutch onto their bureaucratic privileges. This is especially true under the terrifying reality that dismantling the bureaucratic system would inevitably provoke the monolithic, unified backlash of the already coalesced **bureaucratized landlord class** (官僚化的地主阶级).

No matter how spectacularly triumphant the counteroffensive against the Xiongnu appears both then and now, and no matter how blindingly dazzling the radiance of the Han Dynasty at its absolute zenith was, the "wartime bureaucratic system" forged during Emperor Wu's reign ultimately doomed the entire nation, dragging it down a one-way path straight to hell.

And now, it is simply too late to say anything.

13，汉武帝时期的政治改革为什么最终使得中国走上了灾难性的道路

然而就像我之前提到过作为最重要结论来叙述的事，虽然中国在封建化早期进展迅速，但这很难说成是一件好事，因为中国在西汉时期形成的官僚制度最终演变成为阻碍封建化的力量，最终导致了封建化进程的中断和灾难性的官僚复辟。在此前我只是笼统地说：汉代形成的官僚制度过强了，但是究竟怎么强没有具体说，而且仅仅用“强”这个词可能会引发误解。因此让我们回到历史转折的地方再详细勘察一下“案发现场”，尽管汉武帝统治的54年整体上就已经属于中国历史的转折点了，不过为了详查我们不妨把时间再具体一点，放在公元前121年到120年这两年间。让我们看看在这个时间点，汉朝正处于怎样一个十字路口上。第一，霍去病在公元前121年两次出击令汉朝征服了整个河西走廊地区，匈奴等周边少数民族政权对汉朝的包围态势瓦解。在征服河西走廊之后，汉帝国对于北方的控制达到了日后朝代所能达到的水平，适合农耕的区域已经被悉数占有，并且获得了一定农牧混合地区以及马场。第二，在公元前122年淮南王刘安谋反未遂之后，汉武帝相继颁布了左官律和附益法，这标志着对于诸侯王国权利的侵夺已经完成，此后汉朝朝廷已经不可能再从诸侯王国那里榨取油水。第三，在公元前124年汉武

帝设置太学，这连同此前的设置五经博士，完善察举制等举措一起基本构建完成了中国官僚体制的（以儒学为主的）意识形态框架，并且在整体上一一直延续到清朝末年。第四，在河西之战之后文景时期所积累下来的余财因为对匈奴战争消耗已经所剩无几，继续作战势必意味着开辟新的财源，而要在短期内实现这一点不能指望生产力增长实现，而必须依靠新的榨取制度。

至此，对匈奴反击的成功已经使得帝国不再面临生死危机，究竟是在地理上与内地比较接近的，从降水量分布和生产方式分布上处于交界地区的位置进入防守反击的状态，用余力扫荡周边其他政权。还是趁着匈奴遭受重大打击的时刻主动扩大战争，派遣规模更大的军队深入蒙古腹地追击穷寇，站在现在信息更全面的角度是一个很重大的问题。不过在当年人们似乎都不倾向于讲和，这不仅是因为当年的人获得信息并不全面，更是因为匈奴长达近一个世纪的军事压迫很难让人们相信匈奴军队不会卷土重来。毕竟当年冒顿开始他的征服之时，河套地区以及河西走廊也不由匈奴统治。在当时那个时间点，唯一坚决主张见好就收，恢复与匈奴人和平的是主爵都尉汲黯，不过这个人未必是意识到了什么问题，大概率是因为他一贯尊崇“国家少事”的原则，在打完几场胜仗之后觉得谈和更合适了而已。总而言之，帝国的最终决策是扩大战争，其最终目的有可能已经是彻底消灭匈奴。

于是在公元前121年汉武帝时期最后一个在核心决策圈内的丞相公孙弘去世之后，直到要求田千秋辅佐皇子刘弗陵为之，文献记录中再也没有一个汉帝国的丞相在决策层起到作用。这标志着内朝与外朝的彻底分离，现在云集各方奇人异士的古典宫廷退缩到了以大司马大将军卫青为首的内朝中。内朝成员作为皇帝的心腹亲信直接参与国家大政方针的商议和决策过程，而以丞相为首的外朝官僚系统不于政治决策中扮演有影响的角色，仅仅作帝国政府的执行机构存在。这套新体制很快展现出了极强的工作效率，接下来十年间，汉武帝进行了两次掠夺性的币制改革并最终确定了币制，收回铸币权；发动了“全民检举揭发”的算缗和告缗运动，使得商贾中产以上悉数破产；开始执行盐铁官营和平准均输的政策，加强国家对于经济的管控能力。正是经由这些措施缓解经济压力，汉武帝又将他的征服战争和探索事业持续了30年，中国第一次以强国的身份出现在世界舞台上。这样一来，我们就可以明确地梳理出汉武帝的政治举措如何塑造了中国官僚体制最终得以复辟的特征。

第一，与其他国家不同，中华帝国在汉武帝执政时期发展出了一套具有以儒家意识形态为明确指导思想的，有大量官私学校和官方认可学者以及有声望的大儒培养官僚预备队伍的，有一套比较明确的，（官僚制度）有较大权限自行执行的选官制度的（高级官员肯定还是需要皇帝认可）官僚制度，而且范围是全国，不是部分地区。这些特征单独出现一两个并非奇怪，但是一起出现在古典时期的官僚体制中就非常惊人了。古典帝国官僚制度的一般特征就在于随意性和平衡性，也就是不挑着一类人用，最终的结果是体制内各种人都有。它不是某个宗教的教团，而是一个拥有权力的国家机器，以古典时期社会各种思想的繁荣和开放来看，古典官僚制度中成员的思想应当也是多样的。而且我们应该指出，在正常情况下保持这种官僚体制的多样性对于君主的专制权力的确好处，例如萨珊波斯的君主就非常喜欢和擅长在拜火教、摩尼教、各派基督教和马兹达克派的相互竞争中扩大自己的权力，孔雀王朝和笈多王朝的君主也会同时尊奉婆罗门教，佛教，耆那教以及阿吉维卡派（Ajivika）。中国的事态发展也表明，在官僚系统内独尊儒术根本不会在事实上增加君主的权力，从汉武帝以后汉代君主相对于官僚制度的权力不是处于一种上升的趋势，反倒是趋向变弱的。这是因为在统一思想指导下的官僚制度原本就不是为了增强古典君主的权力，而是在面临战争扩大化的现实需求下增强行政的执行效率，并且在节省皇帝本人为了维持日常行政而投入的精力。

汉武帝时期的外朝官僚系统相当于是整个帝国政府的外骨骼，为了让这个附加的机器能够自己正常地运转，而不总是陷入一种需要维修的境地，皇帝就需要给它输入儒家思想这个程序。然而具有指导思想，学术机构以及晋升路径的官僚制度就会出现一种新的变化，那就是官僚体制内产生一种自我意识，许多

官僚认为彼此之间具有很大共同利益，而且从官员选拔和考核的角度确实如此。同时还出现了一大批依附于官僚制度的受益群体，实际上它在汉武帝去世之后很快就出现了，也就是汉代的经学世家。一些大儒之所以被人们敬重，并非他的学问具有多少实际作用，而是拜入他门下学习容易做官，这不仅是学术上的原因也是因为社交关系的缘故。这些官僚制度的依附者最终在我国形成了一个特殊的阶层，也就是所谓士大夫阶层。这种情况下，维护官僚制度本身的存在，而非利用官僚制度去攫取财富和土地成了一些人民根本利益诉求。这一点与罗马很不一样，罗马的官僚制度虽然发达，但是大家在这个体制内晋升的时候想的大多是为自己家族多积攒一些钱财，多购置一些土地，在这个体制内无非顺势而为，并没有强烈的维护现有制度的欲望。中国的官僚系统既然有为数不少的既得利益者拥护，有成员相对广泛的认同，又有比较大的自主行动能力，那么它在面对变化的时候就会有动力并且有能力进行迅速地有效的反应，使自己能够适应变化继续生存。

第二，汉武帝时期形成的官僚制度最大的特征不是“能管”，而是“能抢”，这是很多人，特别是外国人容易忽视的。现在人们对于中国官僚制度的印象往往是高度复杂、成熟，无孔不入，但这其实是一种幻想，我的评价是来中国住上几年就明白了。只要拿罗马与汉朝对比一下就很容易认识到这一点，从官僚体制的专业化程度和精细程度来看，汉朝并非能够与罗马相比。这一点很正常，毕竟东地中海文明发展的时间比中国要久很多，而且各个地区之间交流也十分频繁。例如从司法、审计以及公共工程来说，罗马比起汉帝国明显具有优势。如果从对于社会经济的干预来看，恐怕还要罗马人更加深入全面一些。

当然，人们不应该忘记我们不可能准确对比两个庞大古典帝国的基础性权力强弱。因为即使在一个帝国之内，朝廷对于不同地区的权力也是有很大差异的，例如罗马帝国在很长时间内其公民权授予都具有地域性，人们就不可能指望罗马帝国在亚平宁半岛的基础性权力与各个行省相等。汉朝也是一样的例子，不同的郡被分配到的政治任务可能差异很大。但是从总体上说，汉帝国和罗马帝国所能掌握的基础性权力都是相当惊人的。汉武帝在他统治中国的时候能够进行长期有效的军事动员和扩张战争，离不开帝国政府所能掌控的强大的基础性权力。如果仅靠专制性权力就能击溃匈奴这样的强敌，那么崇祯皇帝也不可能在景山上吊。我在这里想要表达的含义是，汉武帝漫长统治时期的更化运动为一个极具破坏力的，能够提供强专制性权力的官僚制度形成铺平了道路。尽管我们随后就会看到刘彻本人一直在非常谨慎且明智地掩盖其专制性权力。

然而在汉武帝执政那个特殊的历史时期，官僚制度的首要任务并非“能够治理”，而是“能够掠夺”，因为帝国的首要目标是打赢战争。回想一下之前我们在提到清朝征服中国之后吸取了明代皇帝的教训，有意地利用八旗这个入关时已有的体制将一般的行政官员和专职扩大并维护君主利益的官员相区分。这个事实非常重要，因为有一些官僚制度被设计出来的首要目的就不是“增强管理”，尽管在一般的理解上官员似乎就是用来进行管理的。在汉武帝设计这套体制的时候，他首先考虑的不可能是如何做到司法判案的公正这样的问题，而是如何能够持续一段时间的，大规模的榨取民间的财富用于战争，在这种目的下形成的官僚体制必然是偏向“榨取性官僚体制”而非“管理性官僚体制”。在联想到我们在谈清代对于官员进行划分时，从本质上而言，帮助君主扩大财富的专职官僚和负责维护君主利益特别是政治安全的专职官僚属于一类，都是“仆人型”的。因此当古典时期过去，中国在事实上已经不再需要面临汉匈战争这样规模和烈度的对外战争时，“榨取性官僚体制”就很容易向“压迫性官僚体制”转化，变成以维护稳定和扼杀变化为主要目的的机关。

实际上人们也很容易想清楚，压迫的一个最主要的手段就是榨取，只要让老百姓足够穷困和愚蠢，那么他们事实上就无法造成威胁，这也是《商君书》在 2300 年前就指出的。同样是因为出于整个官僚系统的掠夺性而非治理性，官僚系统的过于庞大能够直接毁灭社会生产，这就是所谓王朝周期律的原因。如果人们熟悉中华帝国之后的历史，特别是隋唐以来官僚复辟时期的历史就很容易理解这一点，就国家制度

对于社会基层的管理能力而言，中华帝国还未必比其他地方强多少，即使是中世纪的封建欧洲也不一定能比过。在面临司法案件时，有没有一个能够让全社会满意的程序？在制作财政预算和进行审计的时候，有没有一个明确的流程以确定责任？有没有高效率的市场管理部门来对经济进行调节以激发市场活力？其实中华帝国既做不到这些，也根本不在乎这些，它就不是来解决社会问题的，它只需要能够源源不断地掠夺民脂民膏并避免造反就够了。中国民间有很多话都反映了这种认识，例如“各打五十大板”“衙门口朝南开，有理没钱莫进来”。到现在中文互联网上的流行话有一句是这么说的：解决不了问题就解决提出问题的人。

就我国官僚制度的本质而言，它并不是寻求国家长远发展和做好事的，而是能掠夺多少掠夺多少做坏事的，其威力在于破坏而非建设，是恫吓人民而非令其信服。我们不得不承认中华帝国的这种选择符合政治的基本逻辑，统治者想要使得被统治者臣服，无非只有施以恩惠进行拉拢，加以惩罚进行恐吓，推行教化使其信服三种手段。奖赏意味着建设，说服离不开事实，唯有惩罚成本最低。与其费尽心力使人民心悦诚服，不如制造无休止的恐怖把他们全部吓疯。我认为在中国生活过一段时间并且仍然能够保持思考的人，恐怕不会相信现今中国在公共服务领域真的强于西方发达国家。（只需要想一想自己到公共机关办事的时候遭到什么样的态度对待就明白了）像这样的灾难性后果，从其最初来说，来源于这套体制根本就不是一个汉武帝设置的常规制度，而是在那个年代没有别的办法才设立的“战时体制”。此前已经说过，皇帝本人对于这套制度应当执行到何种程度，在什么时候应该削弱它同样犹豫不决，只不过最后彻底打垮匈奴的野心战胜了其他的判断。

在古典时期结束之后（随着封建化的开始），像汉匈战争这样大规模的大战已经打不起来，帝国能够征服的领土尽数纳入囊中，没有必要再派出无数探险家在未知的远方寻求援助，也没有那么多工程项目需要投资，总之榨取的巨额财富没了去处，然而官僚体制仍然在“取之尽锱铢”。因此正如今天所见，必然的后果是上至皇帝下至底层吏员依照官僚系统内的等级区别都获得了惊人的特权，并且一致地维护起了这套体制。我作为普通人虽然难以想象君主和高级官僚的特权究竟能庞大到什么地步，但事实就是这种特权在中国历史上被证明是难以抵抗的诱惑。任何人无论其身份，无论以何种方式发家，一旦能够取得这样的特权的时候，他都会想尽办法地维持官僚制度并试图保有官僚特权，特别是在摧毁官僚制度必然导致已经形成的官僚地主阶级一致反对的情况下。

无论对匈奴的反攻在当时和现在看来是多么成功，无论汉朝在鼎盛时期的光辉是多么耀眼，汉武帝时期的战时官僚制度最终影响整个国家走上了通向地狱的道路，现在说什么都晚了。